PDM
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NATIONAL ASSEMBLY

MOTIVATION BY JAN VAN WYK, MP, (PDM) ON THE MOTION TO DISCUSS THE CURRENT LACK OF SUPPORT FOR NAMIBIAN MUSICIANS AND LOOK INTO THE ESTABLISHMENT AND DEVELOPMENT OF INFRASTRUCTURE AND RESOURCES FOR THE MUSIC INDUSTRY IN NAMIBIA AND CALL FOR THE DELIBERATE SUPPORT OF NAMIBIAN MUSIC.

12 SEPTEMBER 2023

Honourable Speaker
Honourable Members
I rise to motivate this very important motion that aims to call for the support of Namibian musicians. This motion further aims to call for the development of infrastructure and resources for the Namibian Music Industry.

Honourable Members

Namibia is a country that has a rich deposit of natural beauty and overflows with natural resources. The exact same thing can be said about the music industry. The country boasts an abundance of entertainers from every art form imaginable. Although there is not a standardized structure or system to measure the impact of Namibian music and its contribution to the GDP of the country, it still holds influence and has the potential to be a force that can be reckoned with. Arts education and funding, however, has been at the mercy of the public and private institutions and although there are programs set up to drive the industry forward and create a sustainable creative economy, the progress is minimal.

Namibian music is the driving force behind the industry. There are inherently 11 different tribes in Namibia that all contribute to the different music which are usually performed at traditional events, weddings and funerals. Some popular Namibian music genres include Kwaito, Damara Punch, Oviritje, House, RNB, Gospel, Shambo, and Kwasa Kwasa just to name a few.

Honourable Speaker

Honourable Members

Creative art is one of the biggest industries in the world. A fundamental part of this industry is music. Music can be found in every aspect of our daily life. It is a universal culture for all societies. People listen to music while driving, learning, relaxing, cooking, or doing any other routine activity of the day. Music can greatly affect the economy of a country in a very positive way. The entire music ecosystem offers significant social, cultural, and economic advantages and benefits.

Additionally, music creates numerous job opportunities for individuals. The production of music requires a lot of activities and personnel. The production process creates an avenue where several people come together to achieve a common goal. Record labels and studios have various work positions such as recording engineers, musicians, music producers, composers, and artist managers who all play distinct roles to manufacture music.

Honourable Speaker

Honourable Members

The Namibian music industry, like many other African countries, has a rich history and a wealth of talented artists, but it also faces many challenges that are preventing it from reaching its full potential. The Namibian music industry remains under-developed, with no major record labels or distribution infrastructure. A lack of focus to produce economically viable Namibian music products and the absence of effective marketing and distribution structures are two of the factors inherently hampering the development of the local music industry.

Furthermore, another major challenge facing the Namibian music industry is a lack of exposure and recognition. Despite the country's rich musical heritage, many Namibian musicians struggle to gain recognition and exposure on the international stage. This limits their ability to make a living from their music and to achieve the same level of success as their international counterparts.

Honourable Members

Musicians in Namibia mostly depend on Live Show performances for income and some depend on sponsorships and endorsement deals. Music shows and festivals held and organised by certain Municipalities and Town Councils in Namibia are biased in booking musicians and only book the musicians they prefer. This is discriminatory and deprives musicians of the much-needed income and exposure.

To make matters worse, some of these municipalities, event organisers and promoters book musicians from other countries and pay them high rates while overlooking deserving Namibian Musicians and Artists. This discriminatory practice needs to stop as a matter of urgency. We need to start taking National Pride seriously and give priority to our own Artists and Musicians.

Honourable Speaker

Honourable Members

Previously we had the Sanlam Music Awards and recently the Namibian Annual Music Awards which came to an end in the year 2020. There are however media reports that the Namibian Annual Music Awards will be held this year, but the NBC has indicated that there are still no sponsors for the NAMA Music Awards. Music awards are very important for Artists and also have a significant impact on the music industry and the music lovers in Namibia. Winning an award can bring so much recognition, prestige and fame for the Artists. Winning music awards in Namibia, Artists would normally receive a cash payment, which would in-turn supplement their income. Since the end of the Namibian Annual Music Awards, Artists have not received awards including cash prizes to date. This is problematic in so many ways. We need more than one award show in Namibia for our musicians.

Honourable Members

We need to understand that people have different talents and music is another amazing talent our youth can harness and nurture. It is therefore important to establish and develop infrastructure for up and coming musicians. The infrastructure can be music recording studios at every Regional Youth Office of the Ministry of Youth, Sport and Culture. The Namibian Government together with the Ministry of Education, Arts and Culture should also establish music schools for our youth.

[1]Furthermore, there have been complaints from Artists in Namibia that the Namibian Society of Composer and Authors of Music also known as NASCAM does not fairly pay music royalties to the deserving Artists. There are so many allegations of mismanagement at NASCAM. NASCAM is a collective Management Organization which administers the rights of those creative artistic works, called in a combination word "MUSIC".

Honourable Speaker

Honourable Members

Additionally, some broadcasters (radio and TV) in Namibia do not pay NASCAM the required amount of money for the music of the Artists they play on radio or TV. The Communications Regulatory Authority of Namibia (CRAN) should therefore strengthen measures to hold broadcasters responsible that are bypassing the requirements and rules on handling music. It is high time that musicians are paid for their creativity and hard work.

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[1] https://www.namibian.com.na/nascam-addresses-concerns-strives-to-improve-royalties/

Moreover, I acknowledge the funding provided to musicians and other creatives by the National Arts Council of Namibia, but I believe more can be done to accommodate a large number of creatives in Namibia.

Honourable Members

We all consume music. We all love and have our own favourite Namibian song or songs. We need to develop the culture of supporting Namibian music. We need to start buying tickets to attend shows organised by Namibian musicians. If we don't support our own, then who will?

Honourable Members

We need to ensure that more funding is provided to institutions like the National Arts Council of Namibia for initiatives and projects that strictly empower Namibian musicians. We also need to investigate institutions like NASCAM that don't pay musicians their deserved music royalties and we should also empower these institutions with more financial and human resources to enable them to carry out their mandate in a transparent manner.

Honourable Speaker

Honourable Members

In conclusion, I urge this August House to consider this motion as it calls for the support and establishment of infrastructure and resources for the Namibian Music Industry.

I Thank You